

A Vipassana Method

विपश्यना *Vipassanā*

ORIGINS

Vipassanā?, "seeing things as they really are", descends from the Buddha's own Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta. Its modern revival took several distinct forms across twentieth-century Burma and Thailand: Ledi Sayadaw's (1846–1923) return of practice to lay students, carried forward through Saya Thetgyi to Sayagyi U Ba Khin (1899–1971) and from him to S.N. Goenka (1924–2013), who popularised ten-day body-scanning courses worldwide from 1969 onward; Mahasi Sayadaw's separate "noting" method; and the Thai Forest Tradition of Ajahn Mun and Ajahn Sao. Systematic scanning of bodily sensation itself is not unique to any one of these, it appears, in various forms, across most of them.

WHAT THIS IS

This method shares its opening move with several of these lineages, narrowing attention, then scanning bodily sensation , but the practice as a whole is not rooted in any single one of them. It has developed over years of direct teaching into something genuinely its own: varying the scan itself rather than repeating one fixed sweep, drawing where useful on the dantian and qigong vocabulary many students here already carry, and moving into territory, the governing principles below, and the depth-work that follows the scan, that belongs to this teaching specifically.

Governing Principles *what the practice is actually pointing at*

1 Equanimity <i>upekkhā</i> Craving and aversion are what generate karma, they are, quite literally, energy set in motion. Equanimity does the opposite work in both directions: it dissolves karma that is already arising, and it stops new karma from being generated in the first place. This is not a mood to cultivate on top of the technique. It is the technique, moment to moment, applied to every sensation without exception, whether we are inclined to call that sensation pain or call it pleasure.	2 The Body Is Not What Is Assumed <i>the map is not the territory</i> As inner and outer begin to dissolve into one another, relatively speaking what direct sensation actually shows is that "the body," as we ordinarily understand it, is a concept: a socially agreed-upon, language-supported idea with no real bearing on lived experience. We are so attached to that idea that we override the raw sensation itself in favor of the assumed reality standing in for it, a finger mistaken for the moon it points to. This is close to the old koan of the goose in the bottle: how do you get the goose out without breaking the bottle or harming the goose? Sit with the question as it's framed, and it has no answer. The insight isn't a clever solution , it's noticing that the question was never real to begin with. There is no goose. In the same way, direct sensation shows that the solid, fixed "body" we've been trying to work with was never quite there as assumed.
3 Emptiness <i>śūnyatā</i> What we call the self turns out, on direct inspection, to be nothing more than the skandhas, the aggregates of form, sensation, perception, mental formation, and consciousness, arising together. Beneath them there is nothing supporting, nothing substantial, no fixed essential nature holding the arrangement together. Emptiness doesn't mean nothing exists, it means nothing exists in the solid, independent way we habitually assume.	4 Impermanence <i>aniccā</i> Permanence is the only defining characteristic of anything we could honestly call "the Real." Mountains appear permanent, return in ten billion years and they are dust. Since nothing observed holds still, nothing observed qualifies as Real in that strict sense. Experience, seen clearly, is dream-like: gone from moment to moment, the way mist disperses in wind. This is not a discouraging conclusion. It is exactly what direct sensation, tracked with equanimity, keeps demonstrating on its own, no argument required.

We are not playing with sensation, and we are not indulging in it. The aim, throughout, is equanimity, allowing sensation to move through without craving or aversion, whether we call it pain or call it pleasure.

Where We Begin: Narrowing the Field *a broad area of attention, drawn inward over several days*

STARTING POINT A Broad Area, Roughly an Inch Attention begins spread over a fairly wide area, an inch or so across, rather than pinpointed from the outset. The task at the start is simply to notice that something is happening in that area at all, before asking the attention to become more precise.	OVER SEVERAL DAYS The Field Narrows Across the following days, that broad area is drawn in and refined, so that the details of sensation, texture, pulse, temperature, the fine grain of what was previously felt only as one undifferentiated patch, begin to stand out on their own.
WHERE WE SOMETIMES ANCHOR The Nostrils As in several Vipassana lineages: the nostrils themselves, then the opening of the nostrils, then the area just beneath, a classical Anapana progression. This is used, but not used every time.	WHERE WE SOMETIMES ANCHOR The Navel or Dantian Since most students here already carry a qigong practice, the area in and around the navel, the dantian, often serves as the starting field instead of the nostrils. Either anchor serves the same purpose: a place to begin narrowing.

The Body Scan, Varied *rather than one direction repeated for ten days*

Many Vipassana lineages establish a single scanning pattern, down from the crown to the feet, and back up again, and largely stay with it. Here, once that basic scan is established, the direction itself is varied over the course of practice, so the body is met from every side rather than swept in only one habitual line.

Left → Right	Right → Left	Front → Back
Back → Front	Up → Down	Down → Up

Beyond the Surface *where the scan itself begins to give way*

1	All the Way In Attention keeps travelling inward, continuing in. This is closer to a transmission than an instruction; students who have actually sat with it recognise the difference between looking for something and simply not stopping.
2	All the Way Out The same movement, reversed, attention travels outward until it passes beyond the physical boundary of the body altogether, no longer contained by its edges.
3	All the Way In and All the Way Out, at Once Both directions held together, simultaneously. This produces a very deep immersion into what we call, here, the <i>śūnyatā</i> , not a term from the Vipassana tradition itself, but one that students with a background in ceremonial or magical practice will recognise. This is usually as far as a standard ten-day course of practice goes.

Further Practice

Beyond this point, the same movement can be extended past the boundary of the body into the space of the room itself, and further still. Only a small number of students have worked this far in direct practice, it is mentioned here so that its existence is known, not as a stage every student should expect to reach on a first course.

PRACTICE NOTES

- The narrowing of the field and the variation of scanning direction are both gradual, measured in days, not minutes. Do not rush a student toward "all the way in" before the basic scan itself is stable.
- Whichever anchor is used to begin, nostrils or navel , the choice should suit the student in front of you, not be applied uniformly.
- Equanimity is the practice, not a side effect of it. A student chasing pleasant sensation or bracing against unpleasant sensation has left the method, regardless of how precisely they are scanning.

ON LINEAGE

Narrowing attention and scanning bodily sensation appear, in various forms, across most branches of the modern Vipassana revival, this is shared ground, not any one teacher's invention. What is taught here has grown, over years of direct instruction, into its own practice: the varied scanning, the governing principles, and the depth-work beyond the scan are this teaching's own development rather than a transmission from any single published source.

SUITABLE FOR

As with any sustained silent practice, students with a history of significant trauma, psychosis, or acute mental health crisis should approach extended sitting with additional support in place, and intensive retreat-length practice is not the place to begin.

